

3G in Your Hands

3G is the watch-word in mobile space. Here is what to look for in a 3G handset



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Tech talks sound like alphabet soup to many. For example, when you go shopping for your mobile phone and the shopkeeper tells you about the latest 3G phone, you might get confused. 3G mobile phones are everywhere, maybe one is resting at a charger near you. But what exactly is 3G?

3G is a simple acronym for an upbeat 3rd Generation technology. It is the third-generation cellphone network. 3G technology basically turns your cellphone into a mini-computer and makes it easy and fast to send and receive huge files including videos.

With a 3G-compatible phone, you can watch videos of your favourite TV shows, movies, games, etc besides

enjoying other features. Of course, video streaming is possible over GPRS or EDGE too, but it is very slow. While checking e-mails on a 2G phone takes a long time, 3G phones keep you in the loop all the time without the need to carry around your laptop.

3G phones allow multi-tasking by letting you surf the Internet while talking on the phone. 3G can even enhance your laptop's performance. Bridge the phone to the laptop, and it provides Internet access even when there is no WiFi nearby. A 3G phone can even get traffic updates based on the phone's location.

All major network providers are offering 3G services to customers these days, especially in metro cities, and are planning to expand this network. All you need to avail the services is to get a good 3G phone which supports the offered services.

Some buying tips

Here are certain features to look for before you finalise a 3G handset for yourself:

Dual camera. Make sure that your phone has front and back dual cameras. The primary function of the front camera is to make video calls. There are many high-end 3G phone models packed with multimedia features that lack a front camera. Though video calls can still be made using the rear camera, it is bit of a hassle (applications like 'fring' need to be downloaded on the phone to make video calls). It's always better to make sure that what you mistake as the front camera is not the small light sensor available on the handset.

Operating system. With a 3G connection and handset, the options to access various applications are huge. Make sure that your phone's operating system (OS) supports the various applications available.

Some major operating systems are Apple's iPhone OS, Google's Android, Microsoft's Windows Mobile, Nokia's Symbian and RIM's BlackBerry OS. Different operating systems work differently, look different, have different inbuilt and downloadable applications. And one major feature is their interaction with third-party applications. Before choosing your handset, check whether its operating system suits your requirements. It's better to go for one that has a less restricted library.

Screen size. For accessing multimedia applications, you would definitely like to work on a larger screen. A bigger screen would give you a better mobile TV or video calling experience.

Screen type. If you are comfortable using a touchscreen, it's better to go for a touchscreen phone, as it allows easy accessibility while multi-tasking. If touch